

The Representation Stack

How Reality Becomes a Model

Reality Drift Framework — Representational Systems Brief #6

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What Is the Representation Stack?

The Representation Stack is a model of how reality becomes increasingly translated, simplified, measured, organized, and simulated as it moves through human and institutional systems.

The basic sequence is:

reality → experience → language → narrative → institution → metrics → policy → simulation

Each layer represents the one below it.

Each layer also removes information.

The higher a system moves up the stack, the easier reality becomes to describe, compare, manage, predict, and optimize.

It also becomes easier to mistake the representation for the thing itself.

The Layers of the Representation Stack

Reality

Reality consists of events, relationships, physical conditions, and causal forces independent of how they are described.

It is complex, dynamic, and only partially observable.

Experience

Experience filters reality through perception, attention, memory, context, emotion, and interpretation.

No one encounters reality without mediation.

Language

Language converts experience into words, symbols, labels, and categories.

It makes experience communicable while limiting what can be expressed and recognized.

Narrative

Narrative organizes language into stories, explanations, identities, ideologies, and causal frames.

It selects what matters, creates meaning, and removes what does not fit the frame.

Institution

Institutions stabilize narratives through organizations, incentives, procedures, roles, and systems.

They convert shared interpretations into durable structures.

Metrics

Metrics reduce institutional reality to numbers, targets, indicators, benchmarks, and KPIs.

They make performance visible while excluding what cannot be easily measured.

Policy

Policy converts metrics and institutional priorities into rules, plans, standards, and decisions.

It simplifies reality into categories that can be administered.

Simulation

Simulation uses accumulated representations to model, predict, optimize, or control reality.

At this layer, the system may learn more from its internal model than from the world the model was created to represent.

How Representation Creates Distance

Representation is necessary.

Without it, reality would be too complex to communicate or coordinate at scale.

The problem is not that representation exists.

The problem begins when successive layers inherit the distortions of the layers below them.

A metric does not measure reality directly.

It measures an institutional category built from a narrative expressed through language and filtered through experience.

By the time reality reaches the top of the stack, the system may be operating on a compressed representation of a compressed representation.

The Representation Stack and Reality Drift

Reality Drift occurs when higher layers of the stack become weakly answerable to the lower layers they claim to represent.

The metric continues after the outcome changes.

The policy continues after the metric loses meaning.

The simulation continues after the underlying reality has shifted.

The system remains coherent because its representations agree with one another.

But coherence is not contact.

The higher we climb the stack, the further we move from the thing itself.

Reality Drift begins when the model becomes more authoritative than the reality that once corrected it.

Why the Representation Stack Matters

The Representation Stack helps explain why organizations can meet targets while failing their mission, why AI systems can produce coherent but ungrounded answers, why policies become detached from lived conditions, and why modern life increasingly feels mediated or artificial.

It provides a common structure for understanding:

- proxy optimization
- Goodhart's Law
- administrative burden
- semantic fidelity loss
- institutional drift
- synthetic realness
- model drift
- recursive compression

The stack does not claim that every representation is false.

It shows how truth can gradually lose fidelity as it moves through successive layers of abstraction.

The Core Principle

Representations allow reality to become legible.

Legibility allows reality to become manageable.

Management allows representations to become optimized.

Optimization can then strengthen the model while weakening contact with the world.

The representation becomes dangerous when reality must conform to the model rather than the model remaining answerable to reality.

Keywords: representation stack, what is the representation stack, how reality becomes a model, levels of representation, reality and representation, abstraction layers, proxy optimization, Goodhart's Law, institutional metrics, policy simulation, model versus reality, map and territory, semantic fidelity, synthetic realness, representational failure, Reality Drift, A. Jacobs